Fiscal Year:	FY 2006	**Task Last Updated:**	FY 11/04/2005
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Project Title:	The Effect of Skeletal Unloading on Bone Formation		
Division Name:	Space Biology		
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Program/Discipline--Element/Subdiscipline:	SPACE BIOLOGY--Cellular and molecular biology		
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Human Research Program Risks:	None		
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Space Biology Special Category:	(1) Cell Culture		
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	Skeletal unloading results in an inhibition of bone formation associated with a decrease in osteoblast number, impaired mineralization of bone, and altered proliferation and differentiation of osteoprogenitor cells. Although such changes are likely to be mediated by multiple factors, resistance to the skeletal growth promoting action of insulin like growth factor-I (IGF-I) appears to play an important role. IGF-I mRNA and protein levels rise during skeletal unloading, but the ability of IGF-I to stimulate proliferation of bone cells in vivo and in vitro when taken from unloaded bone is markedly impaired. This resistance to IGF-I is associated with a failure of IGF-I to activate its receptor and the subsequent IGF-I signaling pathways. BMSC from unloaded bone show a reduction in integrin expression, and inhibition of integrin signaling reproduces the findings of IGF-I resistance. Therefore, we propose to test the following hypothesis: Skeletal unloading inhibits the ability of IGF-I to stimulate osteoprogenitor cell proliferation by impairing, via an		

Task Description:	integrin-mediated mechanism, IGF-I signal transduction. This hypothesis will be tested by achieving three specific aims: 1) Determine the points at which skeletal unloading blocks IGF-I stimulated bone formation. This will be accomplished by determining whether unloading alters stem cell commitment to the osteoblast lineage, IGF-I receptor activation, and/or the mRNA and protein levels and/or activation of the components of the IGF-I signaling pathway(s). 2) Determine the ability of skeletal unloading to block the response of osteoprogenitor cells to other growth factors such as EGF, PDGF, and FGF with respect to proliferation and activation of the MAPK and/or PI3K pathway. Those growth factors found to affected similarly to IGF-I by skeletal unloading will be further explored with respect to mechanism. 3) Determine the interaction between IGF-I and integrin signaling in the regulation of osteoprogenitor cell proliferation. This will be accomplished by determining the effect of skeletal unloading on the mRNA and protein levels of the various integrins in osteoprogenitor cells, determining which integrins potentiate IGF-I responsiveness, whether the effect of integrins on IGF-I signaling is direct or indirect, and whether correction of integrin levels, if altered by skeletal unloading, will restore IGF-I responsiveness. We anticipate that these studies will increase our understanding of the mechanism(s) for bone loss in weightlessness, and lead to measures that will prevent or reverse such losses. Specific Aims: 1. Determine the point(s) at which skeletal unloading blocks IGF-I stimulated bone formation. a. Determine whether skeletal unloading alters the mesenchymal pool committed to osteoblast differentiation. b. Determine whether skeletal unloading alters the ability of IGF-I to bind to and activate the IGF-I receptor (IGF-IR) in those cells committed to osteoblast differentiation c. Determine the relative contributions of the ras/MAPK and PI3K/Akt pathways to the proliferative response to IGF-I. d. Determine whether skeletal unloading alters the protein levels and/or activation of the components of the pathway(s) mediating the proliferative response to IGF-I. e. Determine whether skeletal unloading alters the nuclear translocation of ERK, PI3K, and Akt and cellular levels of cyclin D1, p21cip, and p27kip 2. Determine the ability of skeletal unloading to block the response of BMSC to other growth factors such as EGF, PDGF and FGF with respect to: a. Proliferation b. Growth factor receptor number, binding, and activation c. Activation of the ras/MAPK and/or PI3K/Akt pathways 3. Determine the interaction between IGF-I and integrin signaling as affected by skeletal unloading in the regulation of osteoprogenitor cell proliferation. a. Determine the mRNA and protein levels of the various integrins in osteoprogenitor cells from normally loaded and unloaded bone b. Determine which integrins potentiate IGF-I responsiveness with respect to proliferation and activation of the IGF-IR and the ras/MAPK and PI3K/Akt pathways c. Determine whether the effect of integrins on IGF-IR activation requires direct interaction with the IGF-IR d. Determine whether correction of integrin levels, if altered by skeletal unloading, will restore IGF-I responsiveness with respect to proliferation and activation of IGF-I signaling pathways. The bone loss associated with skeletal unloading is of great importance to individuals subjected to prolonged periods of skeletal unloading whether this be in microgravity, in a cast, or following neural injury or stroke. Determining the mechanism by which such bone loss occurs is the first step toward effective prevention and treatment. Our project is directed at understanding this mechanism.
Rationale for HRP Directed Research:	
Research Impact/Earth Benefits:	This proposal seeks to understand the mechanism(s) for bone loss during skeletal unloading. This is a major problem clinically for immobilized and aging patients. Bone is a modeling and remodeling tissue meaning that it is undergoing continual development. We expect such research to enable us to understand whether, and how, the development of cells and systems (in this case bone) depend on mechanical forces, the role of cellular structures (bone cells within their own matrix) in response to mechanical forces, how the bone and bone cells sense and use such forces, and how physical and chemical signals interact to determine biological structure and function (bone shape and strength). Such research will contribute to our knowledge of how osteoporosis develops whether it be by aging, by immobilization, or by drugs. As our understanding of the processes by which bone maintains its integrity is increased, we anticipate that our ability to develop preventive measures and treatment for osteoporosis will improve.
Task Progress:	We have made good progress toward achieving these aims of the task. 1. Determine the points at which skeletal unloading blocks IGF-I stimulation bone formation. This aim was essentially completed as described in the previous task book report. In particular we have identified the critical point as failure of IGF-I to activate (phosphorylate) its receptor. This appears to be due to a loss of integrin expression, and we are attempting to determine the mechanism by which this takes place. 2. Determine the ability of skeletal unloading to block the response of BMSC to other growth factors. We have also substantially completed this aim. As noted in the taskbook report from last year, the resistance to IGF-I caused by skeletal unloading is not shared with PDGF. Thus, the mechanism is specific, and not generalized to all growth factors acting on bone. 3. Determine the interaction between IGF-I and integrin signaling as affected by skeletal unloading. This is the aim on which much of our efforts have been focussed during the past year. Because of the lack of good integrin antibodies for the rat, we have been studying human cell lines with respect to their response to pulsatile fluid flow (PFF). We have determined that PFF activates the ras/MAPK pathway much like IGF-I, and are currently exploring the role of integrins in mediating the actions of PFF and IGF-I on this pathway. For this purpose we have developed siRNAs specific for a number of integrins and components of the integrin signaling pathway, which we are currently investigating. In addition we have obtained a mouse null for the beta3 integrin which we anticipate is important for the skeletal response to mechanical load as well as mice with floxed IGF-I and IGF-I receptor genes. We will be testing the bone cells from these mice with respect to their response to PFF after knocking out the IGF-I and IGF-IR in vitro with infection with an adenovirus expressing cre recombinase.
Bibliography Type:	Description: (Last Updated: 04/15/2008)
Abstracts for Journals and Proceedings	Boudignon, B.; Kurimoto, P.; Nishida , S .; Wang, Y.; Elallieh, H.; Cao, J.; Bikle, D.D.; Halloran, B.P. "IGF-I enhances bone recovery after 2 weeks of unloading." 27th annual meeting of the Amercican Society for Bone and Mineral Research, September 2005. J Bone Miner Res, Sept 2005. , Sep-2005
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Abstracts for Journals and Proceedings	Long, R.K.; Nishida, S.; Bikle, D.D. "IGF-I stimulated beta3 integrin recruitment is associated with potentiation of hte IGF-I receptor." 27th annual meeting of the American Society for Bone and Mineral Research, September 2005. J Bone Miner Res, Sept 2005. , Sep-2005